

VANDE BHARAT EXPRESS

In 2018, India took another leap towards railway advancement with the production of its first semi-high speed train set. Code-named Train 18, later renamed the Vande Bharat Express, it was manufactured by the Integral Coach Factory (ICF) in Chennai under the Government's "Make in India" programme. The first one, bound for Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh, was flagged off from New Delhi in February 2019. In the same year in October, a second train ran between New Delhi and Katra in Jammu and Kashmir.

This engineless train can gain speed up to 160 km/h, reducing the journey time considerably. Moreover, it is equipped with modern facilities, such as onboard Wi-Fi, touch-free bio-vacuum toilets, and a climate control system that automatically adjusts the temperature. The trains also have soothing LED lighting, GPS-based information systems, automatic doors, dual-mode lighting, improved insulation, a talk-back facility for the driver, and a pantry attached to each coach.

The train, one of the fastest to have ever run on Indian tracks, has 16 air-conditioned coaches. It also has two centre executive class compartments with rotating seats to match the direction of the train.

A major breakthrough was its production cost, which was far lower than the cost at which it would have been if imported. It will revolutionize the way Indians travel in the years to come.